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Community of Nyansongo, South Nyanza District, Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): RELATIONSHIP TO OTHER ADULTS

RELATIONSHIP TO OTHER ADULTS

The relation of the Nyansongo child to adults other than parents is for the most part explicitly patterned after the mother-child and father-child relationships, although less intense in form. Children are taught to respect all persons of the parental generation, and they may be chastised by such adults who catch them misbehaving. Adults are said to be more cautious nowadays about beating misbehaving children who are not their own because they fear litigation if the child is thought to be injured. The likelihood of a particular person administering a punishment any more severe than scolding is dependent on the friendliness of his relations with the child's parents. If two brothers are on extremely good terms, one will think nothing of punishing the other's children, but if they are distant and hostile, they are afraid that punishment of a child will be misconstrued and lead to legal action. So it is with co-wives, who discipline each other's children if they have a close relationship but keep hands off if they are not speaking, for fear of being accused of witchcraft should a beaten child fall ill. In any case, adults feel a minimal responsibility of reporting a child's observed misbehavior if serious to his parents. They nevertheless extend hospitality to children who are escaping parental discipline, as mentioned previously.

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A major exception to the above picture of respect and parentlike relations with adults is the case of grandparents. They are much warmer and more jovial toward their grandchildren than other adults are, and children learn that they need not respect them in the ordinary sense. Grandparents initiate sexual joking with young children, and insults, including sexual abuse, flow back and forth between them in a manner which is almost as relaxed as that of

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agemates. A child must never strike his grandparent, however, and he tends to obey the older person's imperious commands despite the surface egalitarianism. The house of a resident grandmother within the homestead is a useful refuge for a child being disciplined and for girls whose fathers are sleeping in their mother's houses. Although grandparents rarely play a part in the punishment of children for important offenses, they were observed curtly ordering a grandchild to stop mischievous acts and even caning slightly once or twice.

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